

Booking On for Duty, Publications & Rostering

Revision Notes — EMR 06-01 / 06-02 / 06-04

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★ = **Must know / Critical information**

1. Rostering

Driver rosters are submitted to the Resource Centre (Resources) rather than to managers directly. Roster clerks are responsible for planning and allocating duties.

Types of Turn

Cover Turns

Used to cover a driver's turn when they are on annual leave or long-term sick. Roster clerks plan for known absences by allocating cover duties in advance.

Spare / Stand-By Turns

Allocated throughout the duty roster to cover for unexpected absences, such as a driver calling in sick at short notice.

- A spare driver may be allocated to all or part of another driver's duty.
- They may be asked to relieve a driver involved in an incident or required for interview.
- They can also be asked to assist with an unexpected train movement, such as taking a train out of service due to a defect.
- Spare turns often have some flexibility built in, allowing drivers to cover complete turns on a pre-booked basis.

Alteration Sheets

Always check the daily alteration sheet carefully and systematically. It gives specific details of any work allocated to you, particularly if you are working a spare turn.

★ Always check the alteration sheet at the end of your shift for your NEXT duty — not just when you arrive.

- If you spot errors with duty times or details, report them to your Resource Manager immediately.
- Failing to check may result in you arriving late or early, causing cancellations or requiring another driver to cover.

Exchanging Duties

- Drivers may swap duties using the correct written form.
- Swaps cannot be guaranteed and are at the discretion of your TOC/FOC — it is a benefit, not a right.

★ You must NEVER change duty without proper authorisation, agreement or consent.

Route and Traction Knowledge

- To retain competency, you will be rostered sufficient work over each route and each form of traction you are signed for.

- If you feel you need a refresher, inform your Driver Manager or Train Crew Supervisor.
- Until a refresher is completed, you will not be permitted to drive that traction or over that route.

2. Fitness for Duty & Fatigue

Definition of Fatigue

Fatigue is a state of weariness that results in a reduced ability to perform work effectively. When fatigued, your reaction times are slower, you process information more slowly, and are more likely to forget things.

'Unfit for Duty' — Definition

The term 'unfit for duty' includes, but is not limited to:

- Suffering from illness
- Dealing with bereavement
- Being under the influence of alcohol or drugs
- Not having had sufficient rest periods or feeling fatigued
- Being under stress or pressure outside of the workplace that could reduce performance
- Violating the recommendations/policies in the working hours guidelines

What to Do if You Are Unfit for Duty

- Know who to alert, when and how
- Report correctly to your manager before your shift
- Understand what the process is for resuming duty

★ You must inform the appropriate person BEFORE violating the working hours guidelines — do not wait until you have already exceeded them.

Colleague Unfit for Duty

As a safety-critical member of staff, you must always report to a manager if you believe a colleague may not be fit for work. The safety of the railway depends on everyone looking out for each other.

Returning After Absence

- After leave or sickness, spend time checking the notice cases, company tablet systems and weekly/periodic publications before resuming driving.
- Check for any withdrawn notices.
- Your Driver Manager may require you to undertake outstanding assessments or medicals before you are permitted to continue driving.

Coping with Shift Work

- Sleep in a dark, cool room (18°C or less) — keep it quiet and use an answerphone.
- A short nap before a shift can help compensate for lost sleep and improve alertness.
- Try to create a routine.
- Avoid alcohol before sleep — it lowers sleep quality and causes early waking.

- Avoid large meals at night when the digestive system is at rest.

Clapham Junction (1988): The Hidden Inquiry resulted in 93 recommendations including banning excessive overtime, restricting maximum working days without a rest day, setting a maximum working day length and a minimum time between shifts. These principles still apply today alongside fatigue indices and Working Time Regulations.

3. Drugs & Alcohol Policy

★ The national legal limit for safety-critical rail employees is:

Breath	No more than 13 micrograms of alcohol per 100 ml of breath
Urine	No more than 39 milligrams of alcohol per 100 ml of urine

- Random testing can be carried out at any time.
- The presence of drugs for which there is no legitimate medical need — regardless of quantity — is prohibited.
- Over-the-counter medicines must be considered carefully; some can impair performance.
- If charged by the police with a drink/drug-related offence, you are required to notify your company.

Note: Each company's policy may have slight variations, but the national legal limits apply to everyone.

4. Booking On for Duty

Booking on (also referred to as 'signing on') is the process of formally reporting for duty. Some companies require you to report in person at your home depot; others allow remote booking via phone, log-in system or company tablet.

Booking On in Person (Face to Face)

- Identify yourself — you may be asked to show your ID.
- By signing on, you are making a legal statement confirming you are reporting fit for duty.
- Obtain and note any verbally advised late information.
- Sign the booking-on sheet to record your arrival.
- Collect your schedule card and any other required documents — some must be signed for.
- Keep a pen and paper to hand to record any critical information.

Booking On Remotely

- Some companies use a Resource Centre to manage train crew booking on across multiple depots.
- Company tablets may be used to book on and receive all relevant notices — they may also contain traction manuals.

On Arrival — Key Actions

- Check you have the latest documents.
- Read the safety and other operational notices.
- Make notes to help retain information throughout your shift.
- Collect your equipment.
- Review the schedule you will be working that day.

5. Documents Required for Booking On

Note: these may be paper or electronic.

WON	Weekly Operating Notice
PON	Periodical Operating Notice
Diagram	Your working schedule for the day
WTT	Working Timetable (if required) + any amendments
STN	Special Traffic Notice (if required)
Public Timetable	If required
Traction Manual	Required — policies vary per company on what must be carried
Train Driver Policy	Recommended to carry
Ballast Circular	If driving an engineering train

Note: You will sometimes see two references to time: Public Time and Working Timetable (WTT) Time. Be aware of which is being used.

6. Equipment Required for Booking On

Train Driving Licence	And Train Driving Certificate(s)
ID Badge	Personal identification
Drivers' Keys	Including Master Key, BR1a Key and Carriage Key
Handlamp	Required at all times
Watch	Or other means of telling the time
High Visibility Clothing	Hi-Vis vest or full HV clothing — must be clean
RT3185 Forms	Signalling and TPWS irregularity report forms
Drivers' Report Forms	Including NR3190 Extended Block Working Tickets
PPE	Boots, hard hat/bump cap, safety glasses, disposable gloves (when required in possessions)
Spare Glasses	Some companies have a policy requiring these

★ **If any PPE or equipment is damaged, defective or unserviceable, it must be reported to your Driver Manager at the earliest opportunity so a replacement can be issued.**

Ensure all PPE is maintained in a clean and serviceable condition. An oil-contaminated or excessively dirty Hi-Vis vest significantly reduces its effectiveness.

7. Train Driving Licence & Certificate

- Valid for ten years.
- If either is forgotten, a spare or temporary replacement must be requested from your signing-on point.

Your Responsibilities

- Carry your licence and certificate whenever on duty.
- Notify the ORR if you change employer.
- Report any loss or theft immediately.
- Ensure — with your line manager — that your certificate is up to date (traction and route changes).
- Provide evidence of medical fitness and general competence when required.
- Advise your manager if you consider your state of health affects your ability to drive.

8. Non-Technical Skills (NTS)

Most of what you do as a driver involves technical tasks, but many failures of technical tasks are caused by non-technical factors — such as distraction, poor communication or fatigue.

NTS Categories

Situational Awareness	Knowing what is happening around you at all times
Diligence	Following procedures carefully and consistently
Communication	Clear and accurate communication with others
Decision Making & Action	Making correct, timely decisions
Cooperation	Working effectively with others
Workload Management	Prioritising tasks and managing pressure
Self-Management	Maintaining your own fitness and wellbeing for duty

★ **Practice makes permanent — always follow the correct procedure, every time. Cutting corners when late or under pressure is when incidents occur.**

9. The Rule Book

The Rule Book (also known as the National Rule Book or NRB) contains the operational rules, procedures and regulations for the whole of the GB main line rail network. It is written and maintained by RSSB.

- You are only issued the modules that relate to your specific role.
- Updates are issued in June and December each year.
- Now also available as a mobile app.

Rule Book Symbols — Must Know

Black vertical line (margin)	New or amended item
Green text	Relevant to a specific role only
Blue 'i' symbol	Additional information available at the bottom of the page
Red box	VERY IMPORTANT — critical information
Three stars (***)	Last time this item will appear — take note

Rule Book Companion Publications

- Glossary of Railway Terminology
- AWS and TPWS Handbook
- Signals, Handsignals, Indicators and Signs Handbook
- GSM-R Handbook
- RS524 — List of Dangerous Goods / UN Numbers

10. Other Publications

In addition to the Rule Book, your company may issue the following:

Appendix to the Rule Book	Company-specific publication that may reflect local operations in more detail (title may vary by company)
Driver Policy	EMR-specific policies above the national levels; guidance on many subjects including defensive driving
Traction Manuals	Technical information for the traction you are signed for
PED Policy	Personal Electronic Device policy
Route Maps	Maps of the routes you are signed for

11. The Sectional Appendix

The Sectional Appendix is a modular document written by Network Rail. It provides local instructions for specific areas of track. Because it covers the whole country, the layout of contents can differ between regions.

Key Contents of the Sectional Appendix

Table A (Route Module)	Maps of the network; specific instructions and special working arrangements; track layout for drivers; line speeds; stations; level crossings; tunnels. A square symbol indicates the speed from the previous page.
General Instructions	Specific instructions relating to a broader area, including the controlling signaller for each section and platform lengths.
Local Instructions	Specific instructions relating to a local area only
Route Availability	Lists where only certain types of traction unit are permitted
Low Adhesion Areas	Locations with known low adhesion issues
GSM-R Codes	Radio codes for the area
Permissive Working	Details of where permissive working is permitted in each location

Distances — Key Facts

1 chain	22 yards
1 mile	80 chains

Updates

The Sectional Appendix is updated on an 'as required' basis by Network Rail — unlike the Rule Book, it is not on a fixed schedule. It is advisable to register online to receive updates automatically.

NESA — Online Version

NESA (Network Rail Electronic Sectional Appendix) is the online version of the Sectional Appendix, available on company tablets. Contact your company to obtain access, or email: nesa@networkrail.co.uk

★ It is your responsibility as a professional train driver to maintain and continually update your personal knowledge of all rules, regulations and instructions.

12. Operating Notices — WON & PON

Weekly Operating Notices (WON)

Published by Network Rail weekly, broken down into separate NR regions. Check the WON for:

- Safety notices
- Temporary Speed Restrictions (TSRs)
- Engineering work
- Signalling and permanent way alterations
- Amendments to operating publications (including the Rule Book)
- You must sign for these if received as a paper copy and keep them with you whilst on duty. They may also be issued electronically.

Periodical Operating Notices (PON)

Used to update your Rule Book, Sectional Appendix and other publications by removing relevant pages and replacing/pasting them, or by writing in the changes.

- You must sign for these and carry them with you.
- Previously published items remain in the second section until the appropriate publication is reissued.
- Signal box telephone numbers and other permanent items remain in the Miscellaneous Instructions section of the PON permanently.
- Supplements (amendments to the Sectional Appendix) are listed at the rear.

PON Symbols

*** (three stars)	This is the last time this item will appear — ensure your publications are updated
Black vertical line	New item in this issue

13. Notice Cases & Boards

Operations Notice Case	Newly issued operational notices and information. Notices valid for 8 weeks; after 8 weeks they must be transferred to a Permanent Notice Case.
Late Notice Case (RED border/background)	Located close to the signing-on sheet. Notices must not be displayed for more than 72 hours unless they are emergency/blanket speed restrictions or a notice specifically states otherwise. If still valid, a removed notice must be transferred to the Operations Notice Case.
Permanent / HSSE Notice Case (YELLOW border)	Long-term Health, Safety, Security and Environment (HSSE) safety and operational information.
Incident Notice Case	Operational incident and SPAD information, including incident alerts that affect the depot and where learning can be applied. Displayed for 12 weeks.
Authorised Walking Routes folder	Contains walking route information for the depot.
Low Adhesion whiteboard	Displays current low adhesion warnings for routes.
Social / Union / Rosters / Leave board	General depot information.

Late Notice Case — Examples of Contents

- Emergency Speed Restrictions (ESR)
- Severe weather conditions
- Emergency Single Line Working
- Emergency Block Working (EBW)

Multi-SPAD Signals

A Multi-SPAD signal is a signal that has been passed at danger (SPAD) more than once in a five-year period. These are highlighted in the Incident Notice Case and require particular attention.

★ **An alert is posted in the notice case after every SPAD. Always check the Incident Notice Case and be aware of known Multi-SPAD signals on your route.**

14. Schedule Cards

Drivers collect a schedule card ('diagram') daily. Take time to go through it systematically before starting your duty to check all information is correct and as expected.

What Your Schedule Card Shows

Diagram Number	Your unique duty identifier
Days That Apply	Which days of the week this diagram runs
Start & Finish Dates	Validity period of the diagram
Reporting for Duty	Time and location to book on
Starting Place	Where your duty begins
Destination	Where you are heading
Departure Time	From your starting point
Arrival Time	At your destination
Train ID (Headcode)	The train you are working
Traction Type Code	The type of unit you are driving
Driver Only Working (DOO)	Whether the train operates driver only
Time On/Off Duty	Duration of your turn
Activity Prefix Indicator	Codes indicating the type of activity

If there are any problems, competence deficiencies, inconsistencies or unclear information on your schedule card, refer to your Driver (Resource) Manager immediately.

15. Defective On-Train Equipment (DOTE)

At some point in your career you will encounter a defect on your train. You must know the immediate process for dealing with it, how to rectify or isolate it, and what to do if you must continue your journey without it.

TW5 — The Framework

TW5 provides the framework of conditions of travel for trains with defective equipment. It often requires the rail company to provide event-specific instructions in their own DOTE document. Always follow both TW5 and your company's DOTE, and speak with control.

Southall Rail Crash (1997): A train failed to respond to warning signals and collided with a freight train, killing 7 and injuring 139. Following this, all rail companies were required to have a formal DOTE plan.

TW5 Covers Three Scenarios

- Starting a journey from a maintenance depot
- Starting a journey from somewhere other than a maintenance depot
- A defect developing during a journey

Reporting Defective Equipment

Report immediately to the signaller	Certain safety-critical equipment must be reported as defective immediately — refer to TW5 for the specific list
Report at first convenient opportunity	Other less critical equipment can be reported when it is safe and practical to do so

Options for Dealing with a Train with Defective Equipment

- Detrain passengers
- Re-marshall the train or provide a replacement unit
- Attend to by maintenance staff
- Take the train out of service
- Reduction in permitted speed
- A competent person to assist the driver
- Provide temporary replacement equipment

★ **Always consult TW5 and your company DOTE. Always speak with control before making a decision about continuing.**

16. Report Forms

As a driver you may be required to complete reports relating to incidents, faults or irregularities affecting railway infrastructure. These are essential for maintaining safety and supporting any follow-up actions.

RT3185	Signalling and TPWS irregularity report
NR3190	Extended Block Working Ticket
Driver's Incident Report	For reporting incidents, delays and faults during your duty

★ **All reports must be completed and submitted before the end of your shift to the appropriate person or department in line with company procedures.**

- Include: headcode, date, time, location (use milepost), nature of the incident, lines affected and action taken.
- Refer to Module TW1 of the Rule Book for guidance on reporting.